

Complex sentences

A COMPLEX SENTENCE CONTAINS AT LEAST ONE SUBORDINATE CLAUSE.

Unlike a compound sentence, which contains only main clauses, a complex sentence is made up of a main clause and one or more subordinate clauses. The subordinate clause depends on the main clause for its meaning.

Ranking ideas

Complex sentences are useful because they can be used to indicate that one idea is more important than another. The secondary idea is contained in a subordinate clause, which has a subject and a verb, but does not make sense without the main clause to which it is attached. Subordinate clauses add information to main clauses.

Zoe put on her coat ^{main clause}
because it was cold.

This is a subordinate clause because it explains why Zoe put on her coat, but does not make sense on its own.

Linking subordinate clauses

Subordinate clauses usually start with a relative pronoun such as *which* or *that*, a participle such as *dancing* or *shouting*, or a subordinator such as *because* or *although*. Many subordinators, including *where*, *when*, and *while*, give a clear indication of the type of information they are offering.

MAIN CLAUSE
Zoe had fun at
the dance class

SUBORDINATE CLAUSES

where she met a new friend.

which finished late.

while the music played.

although she was tired.

until it was time to go home.

dancing with her friends.



Identifying dangling participles

Subordinate clauses often start with a participle, which describes the action being performed by the subject of the main clause. If a subordinate clause that starts with a participle is put in the wrong place in a sentence, it is described as “dangling,” because it has no subject to hold on to. The clause should always be placed next to the subject it describes.

Talking to a friend, the music deafened Zoe.

This is a dangling participle because it is modifying the wrong noun—*music*.

The music was talking to a friend.

Check which noun the subordinate clause is modifying by moving the noun so that it relates to the clause.

Zoe was talking to a friend.

The correct noun is now being modified.

Talking to a friend, Zoe was deafened by the music.

Rewrite the sentence so that the correct noun is next to the subordinate clause.